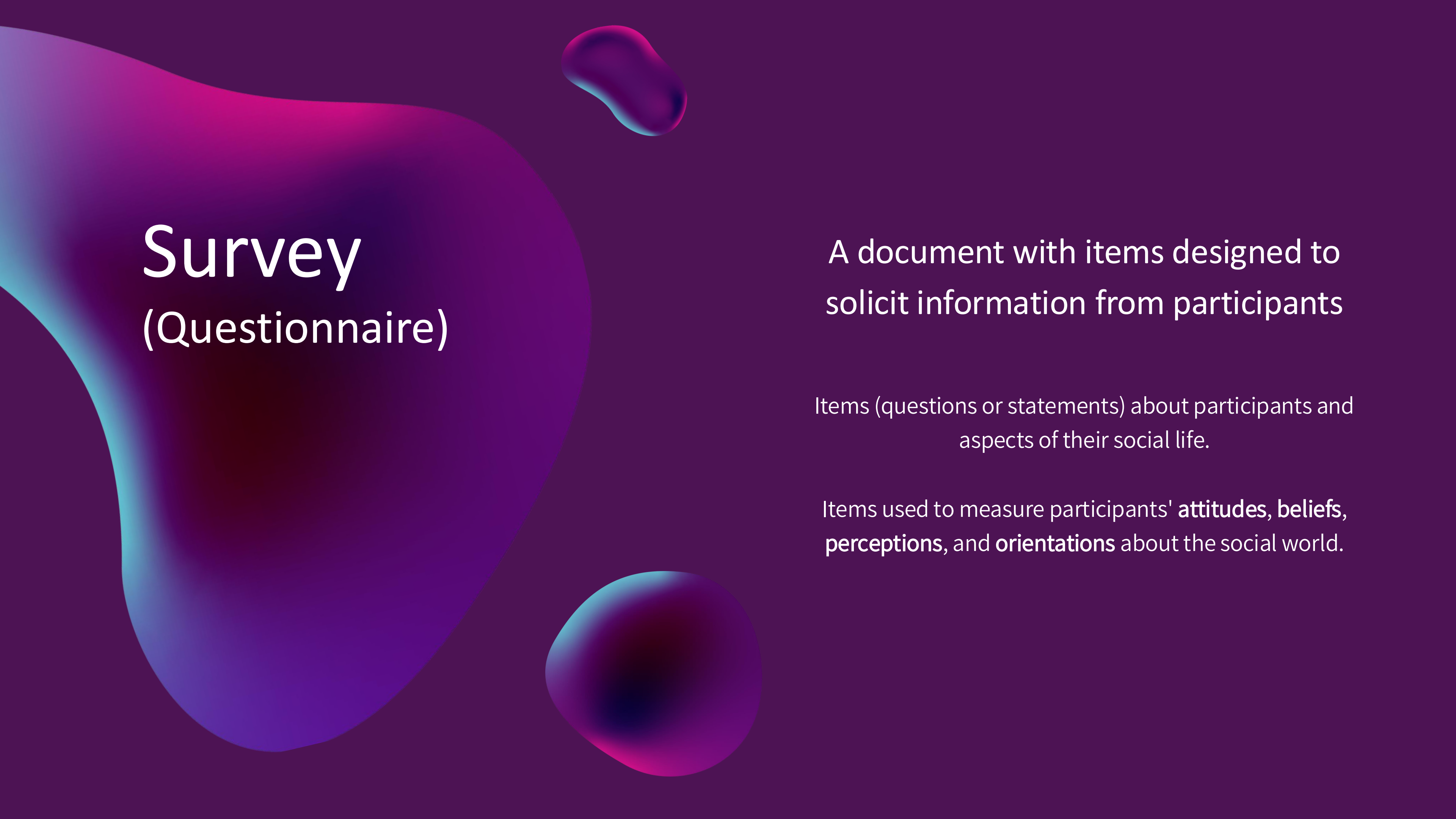


CJ 540

Survey Research

Professor Burrel Vann Jr



Survey (Questionnaire)

A document with items designed to solicit information from participants

Items (questions or statements) about participants and aspects of their social life.

Items used to measure participants' **attitudes, beliefs, perceptions, and orientations** about the social world.

Types of Items

Closed-Ended

Items in which the respondent is asked to select an answer from a list provided by the researcher.

- **Exhaustive:** All possible options (attributes) are available to select
- **Mutually exclusive:** Participants should only be able to select one option (attribute). Some exceptions (e.g. race/ethnicity)

Open-Ended

Items in which the respondent is asked to provide their own unique answers.

- Must be coded before they can be processed for analysis
- Requires researcher to interpret meaning of responses

Types of Items

Closed-Ended

I think this 5-point Likert scale question is an excellent survey question style.

Strongly Disagree Disagree Neutral Agree Strongly Agree

Strongly Disagree Disagree Somewhat Disagree Neutral Somewhat Agree Agree Strongly Agree

24 What is your racial or ethnic identification?
(Mark all that apply)

- ☐ Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin
- ☐ American Indian or other Native American
- ☐ Asian American or Pacific Islander
- ☐ Black/African American
- ☐ White
- ☐ Other: Specify

What is your annual income?

- ☐ Less than \$15,000
- ☐ \$15,000 to \$34,999
- ☐ \$35,000 to \$49,999
- ☐ \$50,000 to \$74,999
- ☐ \$75,000 to \$99,999
- ☐ \$100,000 or more

Open-Ended

1 Is there something that you'd like to see changed about our transit company?

Type an answer...

500

Item Construction (Wording)

“Make Items Clear

Items should be unambiguous

Items Should Be Short

Allows respondent to quickly read and respond

“Items Should Be Relevant

Keeps respondent engaged with content of study

“Avoid Double-Barreled Items

Only discuss one topic per item

“Avoid Negative Items

Including words like “not” can easily confuse respondents

“Respondents Must Be Able to Answer

Respondents should meet some age requirement, or have had relevant experience with the topic in the item. Topic must not be in so distant past that difficult to recall

“Respondents Must Be Willing to Answer

Especially with interviewer administered surveys, some topics, respondents are uncomfortable talking about. May be more willing to respond to sensitive items if they are sure their responses are anonymous.

“Avoid Biased Terms

Including negatively- or positively-slanted language in items encourages participants to respond in amenable ways leading to biased responses

Survey Construction(Visual Design)

Uncluttered

- One question per line

Consistent format

Item Ordering

- Introductory comments and clear instructions at beginning
- Demographic questions at end

17. Beside each of the statements presented below, please indicate whether you Strongly Agree (SA), Agree (A), Disagree (D), Strongly Disagree (SD), or are Undecided (U).

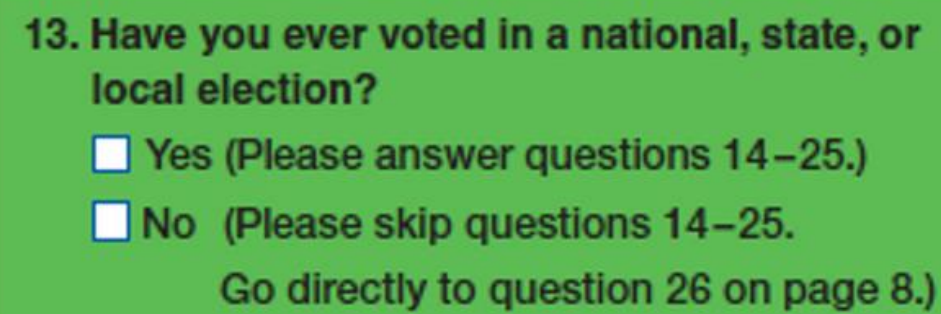
	SA	A	D	SD	U
a. What this country needs is more law and order.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
b. The police should be disarmed in America.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
c. During riots, looters should be shot on sight.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
etc,					

matrix format for similar Likert items

Survey Construction(Logic)

Some questions are intended only for certain respondents, based on their responses to prior questions

- Called "survey logic" (sometimes called a contingency question)



13. Have you ever voted in a national, state, or local election?

☐ Yes (Please answer questions 14–25.)

☐ No (Please skip questions 14–25. Go directly to question 26 on page 8.)

logic in paper survey version



23. Have you ever smoked marijuana?

☐ Yes

☐ No

If yes: About how many times have you smoked marijuana?

☐ Once

☐ 2 to 5 times

☐ 6 to 10 times

☐ 11 to 20 times

☐ More than 20 times

logic in web survey version

Types of Survey Administration

Self-Administered

Surveys in which respondents are asked to complete the questionnaire by themselves.

Interviewer-Administered

Surveys in which an interviewer asks questions of the respondent.

*Most surveys nowadays are self-administered (b/c it's too costly to do interviewer-administered)

Response Rate

The number of people who actually participate in a survey, divided by the number selected in the sample

Ideal

- >70% (>80% for federally-funded research surveys)

Reality

- Ideal response rate rarely achieved nowadays
- Response rate declining
 - ~10% in some commercial surveys
 - ~60% in some federally-funded surveys

Problems and Solutions for Response Rate

Why is low response rate bad?

- Smaller sample = less representative of population
- Participants may be systematically different than non-participants

How to improve response rate?

Use to interviewer-administered

- Yield higher response rates (80-85%) than self-administered surveys by encouraging responses to items.
 - Minimize “don’t know” and “no answer”
 - Guard against confusion by clarifying items

Self-Administered Surveys

Mail

Participants are mailed a hard copy of the survey, along with instructions, stationery, and postage for returning the completed survey

- Costs – distribution, follow-up mailings and/or incentives for returning completed survey

Web

Participants are emailed a link to an electronic/web survey

- Costs – incentives for participation

Guidelines for Self-Administered Surveys

The Survey

- Use simple language
- Test incentives, rewards, and prizes
- Limit studies to less than 15 minutes
- For Web Surveys:
 - Don't force excessive scrolling
 - Be aware of technical limitations

Interviewer-Administered Surveys

Face-to-Face

Interviewer physically meets with participant, reads items orally, and records responses

- Costs – interviewer pay and training, travel expenses, supplies and administration tools, incentives for participation

Telephone (Webcam, etc.)

Interviewer meets with participant via alternative medium (e.g. telephone or webcam), reads items orally, and records responses

- Costs – interviewer pay and training, phone/internet expenses, RDD and CATI expenses, office space, supplies and administration tools, incentives for participation

Notes on Telephone/Webcams

Random-Digit Dialing (RDD) – A sampling technique in which random numbers are selected from within the ranges of active telephone numbers.

Computer-Assisted Telephone Interviewing (CATI) – A data collection technique in which an interviewer relies on a computer, reading items from the survey and entering the answers on the computer

Guidelines for Interviewers

Training

Practice & “Real” interviews

- Practice to handle difficult situations
- Become familiar with questionnaire

The Interview

- Dress appropriately
- Follow question working exactly
- Record responses exactly
- Probe when necessary
 - Probe – a technique employed interviewing to solicit a more complete answer to a question.

Comparisons of Survey Methods

Self-Administered

Mail vs. Web

- Cheaper and faster than interviewer-administered surveys
- Web is cheaper, more efficient than mailing
- If mailing:
 - National is the same cost as local
 - Requires small staff to manage responses/follow-ups
- Respondents more willing to answer controversial items than would in interview-administered

Interviewer-Administered

Face-to-Face vs. Telephone (webcam)

- Fewer incomplete questionnaires
- More effective for complicated questionnaires
- Face-to-face is more intimate, but telephone/webcam is cheaper and more time efficient
- Most people have phones, fewer people have internet or data packages
- Telephone/webcam allow for increased personal safety
- Telephones subject to opt-outs:
 - Unlisted numbers, DO-NOT-CALL registries, voicemails

Secondary Analysis and Surveys

Secondary Data Analysis

A form of research in which the data collected (and sometimes analyzed) by one researcher, which are then made (publicly) available to be (re)analyzed by other researchers.

- Example: General Social Survey

The Role of Surveys in Secondary Data Analysis

Surveys, especially large, federally-funded surveys, are the most common method of creating secondary data for other researchers.



Survey Ethics

Surveys often ask for private information, which must be kept confidential.

Because asking questions can cause psychological discomfort or harm to respondents, researchers should minimize this risk.